LEADERSHIP & DELIVERY / 2026 EDITION

Leadership Toolkit

Lead the work.
Do not manage the theatre.

A SAP Lead is tested by more than configuration knowledge. We need to make decisions under uncertainty, align people with different incentives, handle conflict, protect delivery, communicate bad news early, and keep ourselves useful when pressure rises.

10	20+	10
Lead situations	Practical methods	Scenario drills with model answers

The method is useful only if it changes the next action.

METHODS / CASES / RACI & DACI

Dzmitryi Kharlanau

Personal SAP & AI Lab / Independent educational material

READER NAVIGATION

Contents

A complete printed counterpart of the online Leadership Toolkit. Theory, responsibility matrices, practical cases, model answers and references appear in source order.

INTRODUCTION

Choose the problem before choosing a framework. 4

METHODS & OWNERSHIP

Ten situations a Lead should be able to handle. 4

Make ownership visible before debating options. 6

RACI / DACI

RACI answers who owns the work. DACI answers who makes a decision. 7

Do not fight positions. Find the interests behind them. 8

Describe what happened. Do not diagnose the person. 9

Delegate a result and a boundary. 10

Motivation is usually a system problem before it is a speech problem. 10

Plan what we know, expose what we assume. 11

Report for a decision, not for decoration. 12

A meeting should earn the time it consumes. 12

Protect judgment before protecting busyness. 13

LEARN FROM FAILURE

Fix the system without removing accountability. 14

When the room gets difficult, use five moves.

PRACTISE THE SITUATIONS

Practise the conversation, not the method name. 16

TEN ASSESSMENT CASES

- The UAT handoff nobody owns 18
- A pricing request meets the clean-core rule 19
- Stock exists, but the sales order cannot confirm 20
- The expert who silences the team 21
- Everything waits for the Lead 22
- Procurement and Finance argue over an invoice 23
- The status is green; the release is not ready 24
- An interface fails while teams trade blame 25
- The business wants AI to release blocked invoices 26
- A sponsor adds three countries before Friday 27

Methods worth keeping close. 27

About the author 29

> We do not collect management vocabulary. We use a method when it creates a clearer decision, a safer conversation, a better commitment, or stronger evidence.
>
> We separate people from the problem. We can challenge a requirement, behaviour, plan, or decision without turning the conversation into a judgment about the person.

START HERE / USE THE METHOD

Choose the problem before choosing a framework.

A method helps only when it changes what we do next. For each situation, name the business result, find the missing ownership or evidence, and choose the smallest useful technique.

What is going wrong?	Start with	Useful output
Two teams think the other team owns the task.	RACI	One accountable owner and named people who do the work.
Everyone has an opinion but no one can close the decision.	DACI	One approver, options, criteria, and a decision date.
One person causes repeated problems in a meeting.	SBI / SBII	Specific feedback and one observable change.
The plan looks green but key assumptions are untested.	Pre-mortem and risk log	Failure scenarios, owners, mitigation, and a trigger.
A problem keeps returning to the Lead.	Delegation boundaries	A clear outcome, decision rights, and review points.

Practice rule: choose a scenario , answer aloud before revealing the sample answer, then change one condition and answer again. The goal is judgement, not memorising a script.

FIELD KIT

Ten situations a Lead should be able to handle.

Choose the situation first. Then choose a method. Most bad management starts when we apply one favourite technique to every problem.

01	**Decisions**	Use RACI for work ownership and DACI for decisions. Compare options and close the issue.
02	**Conflict**	Move from positions to interests, evidence, trade-offs, and a concrete next move.
03	**Feedback**	Describe behaviour precisely, explain impact, understand intent, and agree on change.
04	**Delegation**	Transfer an outcome and decision boundary, not only a list of tasks.
05	**Motivation**	Work with autonomy, competence, purpose, fairness, and visible progress.
06	**Planning**	Plan assumptions, dependencies, risks, capacity, and decision points instead of pretending certainty.
07	**Reporting**	Show movement, evidence, risk, decisions needed, and forecast confidence.
08	**Meetings**	Use meetings for decisions and coordination; move information transfer out of the room.
09	**Self-management**	Protect attention, manage load, avoid reactive leadership, and improve judgment under pressure.
10	**Learning from failure**	Review what happened without blame, improve the system, and keep the lesson reusable.

01 / DECISIONS

Make ownership visible before debating options.

Many “technical disagreements” are really authority problems. We first define who drives the analysis, who decides, who contributes, and who only needs the outcome.

Method	Use it when	Working move / SAP Lead example
RACI	A delivery task falls between workstreams.	WORKING MOVE For each deliverable, agree who does the work, who owns the outcome, who is consulted, and who is informed. SAP LEAD EXAMPLE Assign ownership of UAT data, interface checks, and cutover evidence.
DACI	A cross-team decision keeps circling.	WORKING MOVE Name one Driver and one Approver. Contributors advise; Informed receive the decision. SAP LEAD EXAMPLE Choosing API, IDoc, or event for a new order integration.
Decision record	The choice will be challenged later.	WORKING MOVE Write context, options, decision, reasons, assumptions, risks, owner, and revisit trigger. SAP LEAD EXAMPLE Why we accepted a temporary side-by-side extension before a clean-core replacement.
Reversible vs. hard-to-reverse	The team is over-analysing every choice.	WORKING MOVE Spend more evidence and senior attention on decisions that are expensive to undo. SAP LEAD EXAMPLE A field label can move quickly; an enterprise BP numbering design cannot.
Pre-mortem	A plan looks suspiciously clean.	WORKING MOVE Assume the initiative failed. Ask what caused it. Convert the strongest causes into controls and owners. SAP LEAD EXAMPLE Before cutover, imagine billing failed for the first business day and trace likely causes.

Lead question: “Who makes this decision, by when, on which evidence, and what would make us revisit it?”

OWNERSHIP / RACI IN PRACTICE

RACI answers who owns the work. DACI answers who makes a decision.

RACI is a responsibility assignment matrix. Use it when handoffs are unclear: business and SAP teams both expect the other team to prepare data, approve a test, or close a defect. Start with real deliverables, not a list of job titles.

Role	Meaning	Question to ask
R — Responsible	Does the work and produces the deliverable. One or more people can contribute, but the task must not become ownerless.	Who will actually prepare, test, or fix it?
A — Accountable	Owns the outcome and accepts or signs off the work within their authority. Use one A for each row.	Who is answerable if this deliverable is not ready?
C — Consulted	Gives input before work is completed or approved. This is a two-way conversation.	Whose expertise or agreement must shape the work?
I — Informed	Receives relevant updates or the result, without another approval round.	Who needs to know the outcome?

Example: an SAP Order-to-Cash testing and cutover handoff

The roles and assignments below are illustrative, not a standard SAP governance model. The actual approver depends on the project's decision rights. Each row names a deliverable with exactly one accountable owner.

Deliverable	Business	SD Lead	Integration	Test Lead	Release
Agree business acceptance criteria	**A**	**R**	**C**	**C**	**I**
Validate sales-order interface mapping	**I**	**C**	**A / R**	**C**	**I**
Prepare end-to-end test data	**C**	**R**	**C**	**A**	**I**
Execute business UAT and log evidence	**A**	**C**	**C**	**R**	**I**
Assess business acceptance of open defects	**A**	**C**	**C**	**R**	**C**

Deliverable	Business	SD Lead	Integration	Test Lead	Release
Publish the cutover checklist	**C**	**C**	**C**	**C**	**A / R**

Business = Business owner; Integration = Integration Lead; Release = Release Manager. A = Accountable; R = Responsible; C = Consulted; I = Informed.

Read the matrix: for test data, the SD Lead prepares it (R) and the Test Lead owns its readiness (A). Business and Integration provide input (C). The Release Manager receives the status (I). A / R means that one person both executes and owns that particular deliverable.

Question	RACI	DACI
What does it organise?	Tasks, handoffs and deliverable ownership.	One choice that needs analysis and approval.
Who is key?	Responsible person and one Accountable owner per deliverable.	Driver who moves the decision and Approver who closes it.
SAP example	Who prepares mapping, executes tests and signs off evidence?	Should the order interface use an API, IDoc or event-based integration?
What does it not solve?	The technical design, conflicting objectives or the overall go/no-go authority.	Who will do every delivery task after the decision.

Apply it in 15 minutes: list five to ten important deliverables, put one A and at least one R on each row, ask the named people to confirm, and mark escalation when their authority is not enough. A large matrix that nobody uses is worse than a small one that closes a handoff.

Assessment answer: “I would first clarify whether we have a task ownership problem or an approval problem. For delivery, I use RACI to name who does the work and who owns the result. For a design choice, I use DACI to name the driver and the approver. Then I record the next step and the evidence of completion.”

02 / CONFLICT

Do not fight positions. Find the interests behind them.

“We need custom code” and “we need clean core” are positions. The useful conversation is about speed, risk, upgrade cost, ownership, controls, and what must be true for each option to work.

Method	Use it when	Working move / Failure to avoid
Interests → options → criteria	Two stakeholders defend incompatible solutions.	WORKING MOVE Write what each side is protecting, create several options, then compare them against agreed criteria. FAILURE TO AVOID Trying to compromise before understanding the real constraints.
BATNA	A negotiation has a hard boundary.	WORKING MOVE Know what we will do if no agreement is reached. It prevents accepting a worse deal only to end tension. FAILURE TO AVOID Threatening with a weak or imaginary alternative.
Steelman first	The discussion has become tribal.	WORKING MOVE State the strongest version of the other side's argument before answering it. FAILURE TO AVOID Repeating a caricature and calling it alignment.
Escalate the decision, not the emotion	The team cannot close the issue at its authority level.	WORKING MOVE Escalate options, evidence, trade-offs, recommendation, and deadline. FAILURE TO AVOID Escalating people as "difficult" instead of escalating a blocked decision.

Useful sentence: "I think we agree on the outcome. We disagree on the risk we are willing to accept. Let us make that risk explicit."

03 / FEEDBACK

Describe what happened. Do not diagnose the person.

Vague feedback creates defence. Specific feedback creates something we can work with.

Method	Structure	Example
SBI / SBII	Situation → observable Behaviour → Impact → ask about Intent.	"In today's design review, when the test concern was cut off twice, we lost the evidence we needed for approval. What were you trying to achieve in that moment?"
Feed-forward	After the fact is clear, define the next behaviour.	"For the next review, bring the risk and your proposed mitigation in the first five minutes."
Positive specificity	Reinforce behaviours worth repeating, not personality labels.	"You separated data, config, and interface hypotheses before testing. That shortened the diagnosis."

Rule: difficult feedback should become clearer, not harsher. We can be direct without being personal.

04 / DELEGATION

Delegate a result and a boundary.

If every decision returns to the Lead, we have distributed tasks but kept all ownership.
That does not scale.

Level	What we delegate	Lead behaviour
Investigate	Collect facts and options.	Lead decides.
Recommend	Analyse and propose a decision.	Lead approves or challenges.
Decide within guardrails	Own the decision inside defined cost, risk, architecture, or timeline limits.	Lead reviews exceptions, not every step.
Own outcome	Deliver the result and keep stakeholders aligned.	Lead checks evidence and system health.

Delegation brief: outcome, why it matters, decision rights, constraints, evidence of done, check-in point, escalation trigger.

05 / MOTIVATION

Motivation is usually a system problem before it is a speech problem.

We look at whether people can make meaningful choices, become better at the work, see why it matters, experience fair treatment, and notice progress.

Lever	Lead action	Warning signal
Autonomy	Give a real decision boundary.	Every small choice needs permission.
Competence	Match challenge with support, review, and learning.	The same person receives only easy work or impossible work.
Purpose	Connect work to a business outcome.	The team only hears ticket numbers and deadlines.
Fairness	Make workload, recognition, and expectations explainable.	Invisible work always lands on the same people.
Progress	Make completed outcomes visible.	Long programmes feel like permanent incompletion.

Before calling someone “unmotivated”: check clarity, workload, authority, skill, feedback, dependency blocks, recognition, and whether the work still makes sense.

06 / PLANNING

Plan what we know, expose what we assume.

A date is not a plan. A useful plan shows deliverables, dependencies, capacity, uncertainty, risk, owners, and the next decisions.

Method	Use it for	Working rule
Backward planning	Cutover, assessment, release, milestone.	Start from the proof of done and work backward through prerequisites.
Critical dependency map	Cross-team delivery.	Track the few dependencies that can block the outcome, with owners and needed-by dates.
Assumption log	Early estimates and architecture work.	If an estimate depends on something unproven, write it as an assumption with a validation date.

Method	Use it for	Working rule
Risk = probability × impact, then action	Prioritising attention.	The score is not the work. Every material risk needs mitigation, contingency, owner, and trigger.
Buffer by uncertainty	Plans with discovery or external dependencies.	Do not hide uncertainty inside every task. Make contingency visible at the appropriate level.

Assessment signal: when asked for a plan, we should speak about sequence, dependencies, risk and proof — not only dates.

07 / REPORTING

Report for a decision, not for decoration.

Senior stakeholders rarely need all activity. They need to know whether the outcome is moving, what changed, what can hurt it, and where they must decide.

Block	Question	Good evidence
Outcome	What moved since the last report?	Accepted process, passed test, closed defect class, completed migration object.
Forecast	What do we expect now?	Date or range with confidence and assumptions.
Risk	What could change the forecast?	Dependency, defect trend, decision delay, capacity, data quality.
Decision needed	What must someone decide?	Options, recommendation, consequence of delay, decision date.
Evidence	Why should the reader trust the status?	Test result, reconciliation, throughput, defect ageing, signed decision.

Avoid: “80% complete” without a measurable definition of complete. Prefer evidence that survives a challenge.

08 / MEETINGS

A meeting should earn the time it consumes.

Use synchronous time for disagreement, decisions, problem solving, coordination, and difficult human conversations. Move simple status transfer into written updates.

Pattern	How we run it	Output
Decision meeting	Send context and options before the call. Start with the decision question.	Decision, owner, conditions, actions.
Working session	Bring the artefact: process, design, test evidence, data, or incident timeline.	Changed artefact, not just discussion notes.
Daily coordination	Focus on blockers, dependencies, and next handoffs.	Re-plan where needed.
1:1	Use the time for context, feedback, development, load, and concerns that do not belong in a group meeting.	Clarity and follow-up, not surveillance.

Meeting test: if nobody can name the decision, artefact, or coordination problem, we probably do not need the meeting.

09 / SELF-MANAGEMENT

Protect judgment before protecting busyness.

A Lead becomes a bottleneck when every message feels urgent and every problem receives immediate personal attention.

Method	Practical use	Lead question
Control / influence / observe	Separate what we can change now, what we can influence, and what we only need to monitor.	“What is the next action inside our control?”
WIP limit	Limit simultaneous deep problems. Finish or delegate before opening another.	“Which current commitment should stop if this becomes priority?”

Method	Practical use	Lead question
Timebox analysis	Set a point when investigation must produce either evidence, escalation, or a new hypothesis.	“What will we know after 60 minutes that we do not know now?”
Decision journal	Record important assumptions and expected outcomes.	“Was the decision bad, or did an uncertain outcome go against us?”
Recovery margin	Keep some unscheduled capacity for incidents, reviews, and hard conversations.	“If the week is already at 100%, where will real problems go?”

10 / LEARNING FROM FAILURE

Fix the system without removing accountability.

Blame hides information. No accountability hides repeated behaviour. We need both a safe investigation and clear ownership for improvements.

Method	Questions	Output
After Action Review	What did we expect? What happened? Why was there a gap? What will we change?	Small set of owned improvements.
5 Whys with evidence	Why did this condition exist? What evidence supports the next “why”?	Contributing causes, not a convenient single culprit.
Countermeasure test	Would this action have prevented or detected the failure earlier?	Controls tied to the failure mechanism.
Reusable memory	What should the next team know without rediscovering it?	Runbook, check, design rule, monitoring signal, or decision record.

PRESSURE MODEL

When the room gets difficult, use five moves.

01 **State the outcome**

What are we trying to protect or achieve?

02

Separate facts from assumptions

What do we know, and what are we currently guessing?

03

Name the decision

What exactly must be decided now, later, or not at all?

04

Make the trade-off explicit

Cost, risk, time, scope, architecture, operations, and reversibility.

05

Close with ownership

Owner, next action, deadline, evidence, escalation trigger.

ASSESSMENT PRACTICE / TEN FICTIONAL CASES

Practise the conversation, not the method name.

Each story is fictional and uses a common SAP delivery problem. Read the situation, speak your answer before looking at the model, and then respond to the extra pressure. Real projects need their own evidence, authority and approval rules.

1. First 30 seconds: name the business outcome, the missing evidence and the decision owner.
2. Next 90 seconds: explain what you would do, what you would not assume, and how you would prove progress.
3. Final challenge: answer the pushback and the changed condition without reading the example.

Self-check: Did you state the outcome, separate facts from guesses, compare options, assign ownership and define proof? If one is missing, repeat the case.

Case	Primary method
01. The UAT handoff nobody owns	RACI
02. A pricing request meets the clean-core rule	DACI + options
03. Stock exists, but the sales order cannot confirm	Evidence + ownership
04. The expert who silences the team	SBI / SBII
05. Everything waits for the Lead	Decision boundaries
06. Procurement and Finance argue over an invoice	Shared evidence + RACI
07. The status is green; the release is not ready	Pre-mortem + release criteria
08. An interface fails while teams trade blame	Incident bridge + first wrong state
09. The business wants AI to release blocked invoices	Authority boundary + pilot

Case	Primary method
10. A sponsor adds three countries before Friday	Trade-offs + change control

CASE 01 / RACI · OWNERSHIP

The UAT handoff nobody owns

THE SITUATION

Two weeks before user acceptance testing, the business expects the SAP SD team to create realistic orders. The SD team expects the test team to provide customer and material data. Integration says its order mapping is ready, but no one has agreed who proves the end-to-end result. The project manager still reports the workstream as green.

YOUR 90-SECOND QUESTION

You are the SAP Lead. What will you do today, and who must own the result?

ASSESSOR CHALLENGE

> The project manager says, “We already have a project organisation chart. Why create another matrix?”

Sample answer and review prompts

EXAMPLE B2 ANSWER

I would start from the missing deliverables, not from the organisation chart. I would list test data, mapping evidence, execution, defect triage and business acceptance. In a short meeting, I would assign one accountable person and one responsible owner for each item using RACI. The business process owner must confirm the acceptance criteria, while the technical teams own their checks. I would ask each owner to confirm the date and evidence of completion. Then I would update the plan and report that the status depends on these handoffs. A RACI matrix is useful here because the problem is missing responsibility, not a technical design decision.

REVIEW

Notice the concrete deliverables, one A for each, business acceptance, evidence and an honest status update.

CHANGE ONE CONDITION

The business process owner is absent for five days. Who can accept criteria, and when would you escalate?

CASE 02 / DACI · NEGOTIATION

A pricing request meets the clean-core rule

THE SITUATION

A sales director wants a special discount calculation before the next release. The SD consultant says a custom enhancement is the fastest route. The architect warns that the change could increase upgrade and testing costs. The delivery manager has promised a date, but nobody has agreed who can approve an exception.

YOUR 90-SECOND QUESTION

How will you move this conflict to a defensible decision?

ASSESSOR CHALLENGE

> The sales director asks, “Are you blocking revenue because of an architecture principle?”

Sample answer and review prompts

EXAMPLE B2 ANSWER

I would first confirm the business result and the real deadline. Then I would ask the architect and SD team to prepare options: standard pricing configuration, a supported extension if needed, and a temporary business workaround. We would compare delivery time, risk, maintenance and the effect on billing. I would use DACI to name one driver and the person authorised to approve the choice. I would recommend the simplest option that meets the requirement without creating unnecessary long-term risk. I would document the decision, the test evidence we need and the point when we must review it again. The goal is to protect revenue and system health together.

REVIEW

Look for business interests, genuine alternatives, explicit authority, SAP impact and a recorded trade-off.

CHANGE ONE CONDITION

The workaround is legally unacceptable. What new constraint changes your recommendation?

CASE 03 / SAP SD / MM · CONFLICT

Stock exists, but the sales order cannot confirm

THE SITUATION

Customer service sees available stock in a warehouse report, yet a new sales order has no confirmed quantity. Sales blames MM for incorrect inventory. Logistics says the stock is physically present. The customer expects delivery tomorrow, and the discussion is becoming personal.

YOUR 90-SECOND QUESTION

How do you calm the situation and organise the investigation?

ASSESSOR CHALLENGE

> The business user says, “I do not want a technical lesson. Can we deliver or not?”

Sample answer and review prompts

EXAMPLE B2 ANSWER

I would start with the delivery promise and give the business one clear owner for the answer. I would not assume that physical stock must be available for this sales order. We need to check the plant, storage and stock status, requirements, dates and the availability-check rules in this system. SD, inventory and possibly warehouse teams should compare the same material and document evidence together. I would separate confirmed facts from possible causes and set a short time for the investigation. Then I would explain the realistic delivery options to customer service. Only after we find the cause would I support a master-data, process or configuration change.

REVIEW

Do not confuse stock visibility with ATP confirmation. Separate evidence, accountable communication and technical investigation.

CHANGE ONE CONDITION

The stock is in quality inspection. What changes in your options and stakeholder discussion?

CASE 04 / SBI / SBII · FEEDBACK

The expert who silences the team

THE SITUATION

A senior consultant is technically strong and often rescues difficult defects. In three design reviews, the consultant interrupted a junior colleague before test evidence was presented. After the meeting, the junior colleague stopped raising concerns. A delivery manager suggests ignoring it because the senior person is hard to replace.

YOUR 90-SECOND QUESTION

What exactly would you say to the consultant, and what would you change in the team?

ASSESSOR CHALLENGE

> The consultant responds, “I was only trying to save time. We have a deadline.”

Sample answer and review prompts

EXAMPLE B2 ANSWER

I would speak with the consultant privately, not accuse them in the group. I would describe one clear situation: during the design review, the test explanation was interrupted before the evidence was shared. I would explain the impact: the team may miss defects and junior colleagues stop contributing. I would ask what the consultant intended and listen to the answer. Then I would agree on one visible change, such as hearing the full risk and evidence before challenging a proposal. In the next review, I would give all relevant people time to speak and check whether the behaviour has changed. Technical strength does not remove the responsibility to work well with others.

REVIEW

Specific observation, impact, intent inquiry, future behaviour and follow-up. Avoid personality labels.

CHANGE ONE CONDITION

The behaviour continues after two direct feedback conversations. What is your next step?

CASE 05 / DELEGATION · MOTIVATION

Everything waits for the Lead

THE SITUATION

A capable SD consultant asks the Lead to approve every configuration detail. At the same time, the Lead receives incident questions, design requests and meeting invitations throughout the day. Two decisions are late, and the consultant says they feel they are not trusted.

YOUR 90-SECOND QUESTION

How do you delegate without losing control of delivery quality?

ASSESSOR CHALLENGE

> The project manager says, “If something fails, you will still be responsible.”

Sample answer and review prompts

EXAMPLE B2 ANSWER

I would keep accountability for the workstream but change how decisions are made. First, I would agree with the consultant on the result they own, the constraints and the evidence needed. I would give them authority to decide standard configuration details inside defined boundaries. Changes that affect architecture, other processes or major business risk would still come to me with options and a recommendation. We would have short review points rather than approval for every step. This gives the consultant room to develop while keeping important controls. I would also reduce my own work in progress and make escalation conditions clear. Delegation should increase ownership, not remove support.

REVIEW

Distinguish accountability from personal approval of every task. Include guardrails and skill development.

CHANGE ONE CONDITION

The consultant makes a poor decision inside the agreed boundaries. How do you respond?

CASE 06 / SAP MM / FI · PROBLEM SOLVING

Procurement and Finance argue over an invoice

THE SITUATION

A supplier invoice is for 100 units, while the purchasing team can see only 80 units received against the purchase order. Finance says the invoice cannot be processed as expected. Procurement says the missing 20 units are on the way and wants an immediate fix. Each team claims the other owns the problem.

YOUR 90-SECOND QUESTION

How would you separate process facts, SAP behaviour and responsibility?

ASSESSOR CHALLENGE

> The procurement manager says, “Can we just change the tolerance so this invoice goes through?”

Sample answer and review prompts

EXAMPLE B2 ANSWER

I would review the purchase order history, goods receipts, invoice reference and the relevant invoice-verification settings before suggesting a change. We need to know whether goods-receipt-based invoice verification is active and why the invoice is blocked or treated differently in this process. I would ask Procurement to own the supplier and delivery facts, and Finance to own the accounting and payment controls. The SAP team would provide the system evidence and options. We should not change tolerances just to clear one case without understanding the financial risk. I would agree on the correct business action and record who will confirm the final document and account status.

REVIEW

Avoid assuming every quantity mismatch behaves the same in every system. Separate business action, FI control and SAP evidence.

CHANGE ONE CONDITION

The goods were received physically, but the SAP goods receipt was not posted. Who acts first?

CASE 07 / PLANNING · REPORTING

The status is green; the release is not ready

THE SITUATION

Go-live is in twelve days. The status report is green, but several high-impact defects remain open and test execution has slowed. An external interface owner has not confirmed its cutover support. The sponsor says the date cannot move because customers have been informed.

YOUR 90-SECOND QUESTION

How do you present the risk and make a decision possible?

ASSESSOR CHALLENGE

> The sponsor asks, “Are you telling me to delay go-live?”

Sample answer and review prompts

EXAMPLE B2 ANSWER

I would not decide from a colour on the dashboard. I would show what has passed, what is still untested, the severity of open defects and the support dependency. I would run a short pre-mortem with the team: what failure could stop order entry, delivery or billing on the first day? For each material risk we need an owner, mitigation, contingency and trigger. I would prepare choices for the authorised go/no-go group, including the business consequences of proceeding or delaying. My recommendation would depend on agreed release criteria and evidence. I would communicate the uncertainty early, not wait until the night before cutover.

REVIEW

Give facts, release criteria, options, risk ownership and decision authority. Never promise safety without evidence.

CHANGE ONE CONDITION

Every critical defect is closed, but no full end-to-end test has passed. Is that enough?

CASE 08 / INTEGRATION · INCIDENT LEADERSHIP

An interface fails while teams trade blame

THE SITUATION

During a busy order-processing period, incoming sales orders stop appearing in S/4HANA. Sales says the middleware is down. Integration says the source system sends bad data. The business has no single view of how many orders are affected or whether resending them could create duplicates.

YOUR 90-SECOND QUESTION

What do you organise in the first 30 minutes?

ASSESSOR CHALLENGE

> The business says, “Please resend everything now. We cannot lose these orders.”

Sample answer and review prompts

EXAMPLE B2 ANSWER

I would set one incident owner and a short update rhythm for the business. First, we need to understand the impact: affected order range, time window and whether orders are delayed or missing. The technical team should trace a small sample from source to middleware to SAP and find the first place where the expected state is wrong. We would check error messages, correlation references and processing status. Before replaying data, we must understand duplicate risk and the recovery method. I would separate immediate recovery from deeper root-cause work. Once the flow is restored, we would reconcile the orders and agree on monitoring and prevention.

REVIEW

Prioritise containment, correlation, safe replay, reconciliation and clear business communication over blame.

CHANGE ONE CONDITION

Only one customer is affected, but it is the largest customer. How does priority change?

CASE 09 / AI · GOVERNANCE

The business wants AI to release blocked invoices

THE SITUATION

An operations manager proposes an AI assistant that will read invoice exceptions and release blocked invoices automatically. The team expects faster processing, but nobody has specified the allowed actions, error cost, audit trail or when a human must decide. A product owner wants a working demo in two weeks.

YOUR 90-SECOND QUESTION

How would you design a useful first step without giving AI uncontrolled authority?

ASSESSOR CHALLENGE

> The manager says, “If a human still has to approve it, where is the value?”

Sample answer and review prompts

EXAMPLE B2 ANSWER

I would begin with the exact exception types, volume and business cost. We can first test an assistant that explains the mismatch, finds relevant evidence and proposes the next action. SAP remains the system of record, and release decisions follow the approved business controls. I would use historical or synthetic cases to measure accuracy, wrong recommendations and time saved. For a first pilot, a human should review the proposed actions, especially where payment and compliance are affected. Only after reliable results and formal approval would we consider narrowly controlled automation. I would also define logging, access rights and a clear way to stop or reverse an action when possible.

REVIEW

Define measurable value, approval authority, audit evidence, security and failure handling; do not confuse recommendation with posting authority.

CHANGE ONE CONDITION

The assistant works well on common cases but fails on rare high-value invoices. What changes?

CASE 10 / NEGOTIATION · EXECUTIVE COMMUNICATION

A sponsor adds three countries before Friday

THE SITUATION

The project is ready to test an initial sales process for one country. At a steering meeting, a sponsor asks to include three more countries in the same release. Local taxes, pricing and shipping rules have not been analysed. The sponsor calls the change “just copying configuration” and says there is no extra budget.

YOUR 90-SECOND QUESTION

What do you say in the meeting, and what do you do after it?

ASSESSOR CHALLENGE

> The sponsor replies, “A Lead should find a way, not tell me what is impossible.”

Sample answer and review prompts

EXAMPLE B2 ANSWER

I would acknowledge the business reason for the request and make the missing information visible. Adding countries may affect tax, pricing, logistics, master data, integration and testing. I would not give an estimate before a short impact review. I would offer choices: keep the original release, add one country after clear acceptance criteria, or expand scope with an agreed change in date and capacity. For each choice I would explain risk and evidence needed. I would ask the authorised sponsor to confirm the priority and record the decision. My job is to find feasible options and explain their consequences, not to accept a promise we cannot support.

REVIEW

Negotiate outcome rather than defend a fixed position; provide feasible options, scope impact and recorded commitment.

CHANGE ONE CONDITION

The extra countries become a legal requirement. How do you replan and communicate the change?

REFERENCES

Methods worth keeping close.

These sources explain several of the techniques used above. We adapt them to SAP delivery rather than copying a management playbook mechanically.

Source	Useful for	Open
Atlassian — RACI chart	Responsible, Accountable, Consulted and Informed for task ownership.	atlassian.com
Atlassian Team Playbook — DACI	Decision roles: Driver, Approver, Contributors, Informed.	atlassian.com
Atlassian Team Playbook — Pre-mortem	Finding failure modes before delivery.	atlassian.com
Center for Creative Leadership — SBI	Specific feedback through Situation, Behaviour, Impact and intent inquiry.	ccl.org
Harvard Program on Negotiation — BATNA	Defining the best alternative before a negotiation reaches impasse.	pon.harvard.edu
Atlassian Team Playbook — Roles and Responsibilities	Clarifying team ownership and unassigned responsibilities.	atlassian.com

> Memory model: outcome → facts → decision → trade-off → owner → evidence.
>
> When we lose the thread in a difficult Lead situation, this sequence is usually enough to recover it.

NOTES ON AUTHORSHIP

About the author

Dzmitryi Kharlanau

Senior SAP Consultant at EPAM Systems

Dzmitryi works across SAP SD, MM, end-to-end logistics, master data, integrations and enterprise operations. His personal technical lab explores practical SAP engineering, reliable delivery, AI tools and methods for making complicated work easier to understand and manage.

This guide is part of that personal knowledge base. It connects clear leadership practices with the situations that SAP consultants face when responsibilities, technical evidence and business deadlines meet.

dkharlanau.github.io

github.com/dkharlanau

linkedin.com/in/dkharlanau

Independent, non-commercial educational material. It is not an official publication of EPAM Systems or SAP and does not represent either organisation. The scenarios are fictional; SAP behaviour and approval boundaries must be verified in the relevant landscape.

Source: dkharlanau.github.io/labs/assessment/leadership-toolkit/